the BJP has adapted not just from the RSS but also from the Communist movement. Early BJP leaders, while being ideologically opposed to the Left, were often inspired by the personal ideals of many of its senior leaders. As a senior BJP leader told me with grudging admiration, 'There are many things you learn from Communists in their approach. For example, when CPI's D. Raja retired, he stayed in VP House in Delhi. As a Member of Parliament he was allotted it, and he was allocated a bungalow also, but his party said it will decide how many rooms in a bungalow you are supposed to use for your personal use. This ethic is written in their constitution also. If you visit the CPI(M) website, you will find it there. That is remarkable.'

A senior BJP leader attributed the focus on intellectual pursuits and research to the influence in Maharashtra of the Rashtra Seva Dal (RSD). It was formed by socialist leaders S.M. Joshi, N.G. Goray and Shirubhau Limaye with the expressed objective of countering the growing influence of the RSS during the pre-Independence years. As a senior BJP leader from Maharashtra said, 'Especially in Maharashtra, there is special tussle between the RSS and RSD. In the 1940s, in Maharashtra, the situation was such that any boy of ten-plus years would go to either an RSS shakha or an RSD shakha. They also had shakhas like RSS, but they always paid attention to intellectual development, unlike the Sangh. Sangh has a tradition of saying don't debate, but focus instead on winning the heart of the person in front of you. We used to be told, we will win minds later, first win the heart. But the socialists did not think like this. They developed an intellectual climate, which we did not develop, relatively speaking. Early socialist leaders like Madhu Limaye were on par intellectually with Vajpayee and Advani. Sangh-vaalaas, the joke went in Maharashtra, were perfect below the neck, above the neck they had nothing. This changed after the Emergency, but even now there is not that much change. We frequently admit that.'

BJP's Cadre-building: The Prehistory of the Modi–Shah Era

The focus on cadre training in the BJP goes back to Advani's tenure as party president in the early 1980s. Advani was 'one of the